CHAPTER 8

Working Stage of a Group

Introduction
Progressing to the Working Stage
Leader Interventions in Working With a Member's Fear
Tasks of the Working Stage
Therapeutic Factors That Operate in a Group
Coleader Issues During the Working Stage
Points to Remember
Exercises
Guide to Groups in Action: Evolution and Challenges DVD and Workbook



CHAPTER LEARNING OBJECTIVES

1. Describe the dynamics associated with group process and development (CACREP, 2016, Standard B)
2. Demonstrate various leader interventions for exploring a member's fears at various stages of a group
3. Identify and define the key characteristics of a group during the working stage
4. Highlight the differences between a working group and a nonworking group
5. Identify ethical and culturally relevant strategies for designing and facilitating groups (CACREP, 2016, Standard G)
6. Become familiar with choices to be made during the working stage
7. Discuss the specific therapeutic factors and how they contribute to group effectiveness (CACREP, 2016, Standard C)
8. Present guidelines for member self-disclosure
9. Present guidelines for leader self-disclosure
10. Describe guidelines for giving and receiving feedback
11. Identify coleader issues at the working stage

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You have been conducting a domestic violence group for male offenders for the past several months. In your last meeting, one of the members began to talk about his experiences of being raised in a home with violence and severe domestic abuse. The member went into painful details about an incident in which his father was drunk and almost killed his mother. As the member shared his story, other group members seemed visibly affected. Some were fighting back tears, and others were agitated. One member who rarely participated remarked, "Your story is so disturbing. I can hardly stand listening to it." The member who shared his experiences replied, "I've never talked about this stuff to anyone before. It feels like a weight is off of me to finally say it out loud." Another member responded by telling him that he was brave to tell his story and then revealed his own history of having been abused as a child.

- What would you say to the members who disclosed their stories of abuse?
- Would you address the reactions of the other members?
- How would you decide which member to attend to when several had observable emotional reactions?
- Are there any ethical or legal implications related to these disclosures?
- How might you link the members' acts of domestic violence to their own victimization as children?
- If a member were to ask, "Why do we need to talk about all these painful experiences?" how would you reply?
- How would you handle the situation if your own painful childhood memories were evoked?

Introduction

The working stage is characterized by the commitment of members to explore significant problems they bring to the sessions and by their attention to the dynamics within the group. At this time in a group's evolution, we find that less structuring and intervention is required than during the initial and transition stages. By the working stage, participants have learned how to involve themselves in group interactions without waiting to be invited into an interaction. As members assume greater responsibility for the work that occurs, they play a key role in the direction a group takes. This does not mean that the members become coleaders, but members do initiate work more readily.

There are no arbitrary dividing lines between the phases of a group. In practice there is considerable overlapping of stages, and this is especially true of movement from the transition stage to the working stage. For example, assume that Vance says, "There is something I want to talk about, but I'm afraid that some people might make fun of me." If Vance stops with this comment and declines an invitation to say more, his behavior would be transitional. However, if he decides to go further, he may discover that the very people he feared would make fun of him support him. With that decision and Vance's willingness to express what is on his mind, he may be able to accomplish deeper work.

Groups do not all evolve to a true working level, but significant work takes place at every stage of a group. Even when groups are stuck, embroiled in conflict, or when members are extremely anxious and hesitant, many lessons can be

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learned. Some groups may not reach the working stage because members do not develop sufficient trust, cohesion, and continuity. As we described earlier, group participants who are unwilling to deal with hidden agendas, refuse to work with conflicts that are obvious, lack the motivation to participate in a group, or are stopped by their anxieties and fears are unable to create the climate and cohesion within the group that allows for deeper exploration. Factors such as time limits and shifting membership from session to session also may contribute to a group not reaching a working stage.

Being in a working stage as a group does not imply that all members function optimally. All members are not at the same level of readiness. Indeed, some members may be on the fringe, some may not yet be ready for in-depth exploration, and some may not feel they are an integral part of the group. Conversely, a difficult group might well have one or more members who are willing to engage in productive work. Some may be more motivated than others, and some may be less willing to take risks. Individual differences among members are characteristic of all group stages.

Here are some of the questions we examine in this chapter:

- How does a leader facilitate a group's movement from the transition stage to the working stage?
- Once a member identifies a fear, how might you work differently with this fear depending on the stage of a group's development?
- What are some of the factors that influence change within an individual and a group, and how do these changes come about?
- How does cohesion foster a spirit of productivity among group members?
- How are leader and member self-disclosures particularly important during the working stage?
- What kind of feedback is especially valuable to members during a working stage? What are some guidelines for giving and receiving feedback?
- What are some potential coleader issues to consider at this stage?

LO1

Progressing to the Working Stage

For a group to reach the working stage, it is essential that members make a commitment to face and work through barriers that interfere with the group's progress. Meaningful work and learning occur at every stage of a group; however, deeper exploration and an increased level of group cohesion are typical of the working stage of a group. The following examples illustrate how a leader's interventions can assist a group in transition to move deeper into a working phase.

EXAMPLE: Frank and Judy complain that the group is stagnant and that they are getting tired of it. They are likely to back off if the leader responds defensively. Therapeutic interventions could be any of the following:

- What would you like to see happening?
- What can you do to make this group more productive for you?

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- Is there anything you can do to be more the type of member you want others to be?
- You might have some reactions to the way I'm leading. Is there anything you need to say to me?

These interventions can help Frank and Judy go beyond complaining, explore the source of their dissatisfaction, and express what they would like to see happen.

When Ryan, another member, makes a sarcastic remark ("If you don't like it, leave the group."), the leader asks Ryan to make some direct statements to Frank and Judy instead of dismissing them. As Ryan talks about his own reactions to Judy and Frank, he might well identify and get involved in his own issues in a deeply personal way, bringing into the group some unresolved business he has with others in his life. If the leader does not address Ryan's sarcastic remarks, they most likely will have a negative impact on the group.

EXAMPLE: Sunny says that she is afraid of talking about herself in the group. A good place to begin is with her admission that she feels judged. The leader can further Sunny's work by intervening in any of these ways:

- Would you be willing to talk to one person in here who you think might judge you? Tell that person all the things you imagine he or she would think about you?
- Go around to each member and finish this sentence: 'If I let you know me, I'm afraid you would judge me by..."
- Would you be willing to close your eyes and imagine all the judgments people in here could possibly make about you? Don't verbalize what you imagine, but do let yourself feel what it is like to be judged by everyone in the group.

Each of these interventions has the potential for leading to greater exploration, which can assist Sunny in learning how she allows herself to be inhibited by her fear of others' judgments. If she follows any of these leader suggestions, she has a basis for working through her fears. She will probably discover that she makes many unfounded assumptions about people.

EXAMPLE: Jennifer says to the group leader: "I never get any attention in the group, and you seem more attentive to other members." The leader does not rush to convey that she is indeed a valued member, instead he asks Jennifer to talk directly to the members she believes get more of his attention. She talks about her feelings about being pushed aside. At some point the leader intervenes, saying "I wonder if the feelings you are having in this group are familiar to you in your life outside of group?" This intervention can encourage Jennifer to work in greater depth on connecting her past and present outside life with reactions she is having in the here-and-now context of her group.

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If Jennifer acknowledges that she often feels ignored and pushed aside in her family of origin, especially by her father, the leader can give her an opportunity to continue her work by helping her explore some of the ways she might be identifying the leader with her father. Once Jennifer recognizes that she is mixing feelings toward the leader with feelings she has toward her father, she is freer to work on her issues with her father. She may discover that she is often overly sensitive to the ways older male authority figures interact with her. She has read into these interactions much more than is warranted.

Jennifer's declaration that she does not get proper attention in the group is a typical reaction during the transition stage. As the leader works with this feeling, Jennifer ends up having new insight regarding how she is making the group leader (and others) into her father. Jennifer's insights and behavior changes are indicative of significant interaction in the working stage. The leader's intervention did not entrench her feelings of being ignored further but resulted in some significant work on her part. In addition, she might well experience intense emotions over her feelings about her father, and she is likely to express and explore such painful feelings in the group. As a result of her work in the group, Jennifer now pays attention to how she feels when she is with her father and tries out new ways of responding to him. Because she is aware of her tendency to attribute certain qualities to men in authority, she is now in a position to react differently toward them.

LO2

Leader Interventions in Working With a Member's Fear

Members may become more aware of their apprehensions as they experience the group process. As the group (and individuals) moves through the stages, the leader's relationship with individual members will become deeper, and the leader's interventions will likely be different. To illustrate this progression, let's examine how one member's fear would be addressed at each group stage. Grace, a member of an ongoing group, says, "I'm afraid people in here will be critical. I rehearse endlessly before I speak because I want to express myself clearly so others won't think I'm incoherent." Grace is aware that she wants to appear intelligent. She states that her fears get in the way of freely participating in the group. We find that group members often express a range of apprehensions similar to those disclosed by Grace, fearing that others will see them as stupid, incoherent, weird, selfish, and the like. The techniques we describe in working with Grace's particular fear of being judged can easily be applied to these other fears. The way we work with her differs according to the depth of the relationship we have established with her.

Interventions at the Initial Stage

During the initial stage, our interventions are aimed at providing encouragement for Grace to say more about her fear of being judged and to talk about how this

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fear is affecting what she is doing in the group. We facilitate a deeper exploration of her concern in any of the following ways:

- We encourage other members to talk about any fears they have, especially their concerns over how others perceive them. If Susan also says that she fears others' reactions, we can ask her to talk directly to Grace about her fears. (Here we are teaching member-to-member interaction.)
- After the exchange between Susan and Grace, we ask, "Do any of the rest of you have similar feelings?" (Our aim is to involve others in this interaction by stating ways in which they identify with Susan and Grace.)
- Members who have fears that they would like to explore are invited to share their fears with Grace. We leave the structure open ended, so they can talk about whatever fears they are experiencing. (In a nonthreatening way we link Grace's work with that of others, and both trust and cohesion are being established.)

Interventions at the Transition Stage

If during the transition stage Grace makes the statement, "I'm afraid people in here will be critical," we are likely to encourage her to identify ways in which she has already inhibited herself because of her fear of judgment. She can be asked to say *how* she experiences her particular fear in this group. Such an intervention demands more of her than our interventions at the initial stage. We ask her questions such as these:

- When you have that fear, who are you most aware of in this room?
- What are your fears about?
- How have your fears stopped you in this group?
- What are some of the things you have been thinking and feeling but have not expressed?

Grace eventually indicates she is concerned about how three group members in particular will think about her and about how they might judge her. We suggest to Grace that she speak to the people she feels would most likely judge her and tell them what she imagines they are thinking and feeling about her. In this way we get Grace to acknowledge her possible projections and to learn how to check out her assumptions. We are also gathering data that can be useful for exploration later in the group.

We can bring group members into this interaction by inviting them to give their reactions to what Grace has just said. The interchange between her and other members can lead to further exploration. Grace has probably created some distance between herself and others in the group by avoiding them out of fear of their negative reactions. By talking about her reactions to others, she is taking responsibility for the distance she has partially created. She can work out a new stance with those she has been avoiding.

The work that we have just described could be done during any stage. What makes this scenario characteristic of the transition stage is the fact that members are beginning to express reactions and perceptions that they have been aware of but have kept to themselves.

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Interventions at the Working Stage

If Grace discloses her fear during the working stage, we look for ways to involve the entire group in her work. Members may acknowledge how they feel put off by her, how they feel judged by her, or how they really do not know her. Of course, these members' reactions need to be dealt with in an effective way. By expressing feelings that they have kept to themselves, members are moving out of the transition stage and into the working stage. They acknowledge reactions and perceptions, clear up projections and misunderstandings, and work through any possible conflict. The group can get stuck in the transition stage if people do not go further and express reactions that have undermined their level of trust. A group moves into the working stage as members commit to working through an impasse, particularly their own end of it.

We can use other techniques to help Grace attain a deeper level of self-exploration. One is to ask her to identify people in her life who she feels have judged her, enabling her to connect her past struggles to her present ones. We may then ask her to tell some members how she has felt toward significant people in her life. She may even let others in the group "become" these significant figures and may say things to them that she has kept to herself. Of course, doing this may well serve as a catalyst for getting others to talk about their unfinished business with important figures in their lives.

Here are some other strategies we might use:

- Grace can be invited to simply talk more about what it is like for her to be in this group with these fears: "What have you wanted to say or do that you were afraid to say or do?" "If you didn't have the fear of being judged, how might you be different in this group?"
- Grace can role-play with a member who reminds her of her mother, who often cautioned her about thinking before she speaks.
- Grace can write an uncensored letter to her mother, which she does not mail.
- By using role reversal, Grace can "become" her mother and go around to each person in the room, telling them how they should behave.
- Grace can monitor her own behavior between group sessions, taking special note of those situations in daily life in which she stops herself because of her fear of being judged.
- Using cognitive procedures, Grace can pay more attention to her self-talk and eventually learn to give herself new messages. Instead of accepting self-defeating messages, she can begin to say constructive things to herself. She can change her negative beliefs and expectancies to positive ones.
- Grace can decide to try new behaviors during the group such as thinking out loud instead of rehearsing silently as she typically does.
- Both in the group and in daily life, Grace can make a contract to forge ahead with what she wants to say or do despite her fears.

As can be seen, our interventions in working with Grace's fear are geared to the level of trust that has been established in the group, the quality of our relationship with her, and the stage of the group's development. We hope Grace has learned the value of checking out her assumptions about others. We challenge her to continue acting in new ways, even if this means putting herself in places where

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she runs the risk of being judged for some of her thoughts, feelings, and actions. By now Grace may have developed the personal strength to challenge her fears rather than allowing herself to be controlled by them. She realizes that it is not necessary for her to think through everything she wants to say. Instead, she can be spontaneous in expressing her thoughts and feelings without expecting judgment.

Interventions in the Final Stage

We ask Grace to reflect on how the changes she has practiced in the group might affect significant people in her life. She considers the possible consequences of relating in this new way and whether her new behaviors will help her to be heard. Although Grace's work may be effective in her group, we caution her that these new behaviors may not work as well in her everyday life. In the final stage of the group, we emphasize the importance for Grace to review what she has learned, to understand how she acquired these insights, and to continue to translate her insights into behavioral changes outside of the group.

LO3

Tasks of the Working Stage

Even if the group reaches a high level of intensity during the working stage, the group may not remain at that level. The group may stay on a plateau for a time and then return to an earlier developmental phase characterized by issues faced during the initial and transition stages. Periods of stagnation are normal and can be expected; if they are recognized, they can be challenged and resolved. Because groups are not static entities, both the leader and the members have the task of accurately assessing a group's ever-changing character, as well as its effectiveness.

Group Norms and Behavior

During the working stage, group norms that were formed in earlier stages are further developed and solidified. Members are more aware of facilitative behaviors, and unspoken norms become more explicit. At this time the following group behaviors tend to be manifested:

- Members are provided with both support and challenge; they are reinforced for making behavioral changes both inside and outside of the sessions.
- The leader employs a variety of therapeutic interventions designed for further self-exploration and that lead to experimentation with new behavior.
- Members increasingly interact with one another in more direct ways; there is less dependence on the leader for direction and less eye contact directed toward the leader as members talk.
- If interpersonal conflicts emerge within the group, they become the basis of discussion and tend to be worked through. Members discover how they deal with conflict in everyday situations by paying attention to how they interact with one another in the group.

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- A healing capacity develops within the group as members increasingly experience acceptance of who they are. There is less need to put up facades as members learn that they are respected for showing deeper facets of themselves.

In the next section we discuss the factors that differentiate a working group from a nonworking one.

Contrasts Between a Working Group and a Nonworking Group

LO4

Growth and progress look different depending on the type of group and the members in it. For example, progress in a group of court ordered sex offenders may look very different from progress in a group of graduate students in the counseling profession. The table describes typical member behaviors that you may experience as the leader during the working stage of a group. Which member behaviors would act as a trigger for you as a leader? How would you respond? Would you tend to take on all the responsibility for what is occurring in the group? Would you blame yourself, your coleader, or the members for what is happening in the group? Would you share your reactions with the group? Why or why not? Refer to the table as a guideline and a catalyst to get you thinking about what progress will like look in your members and in the group.

In the working group list, the behavioral descriptions represent the ideal; even in the best groups, not everyone will function at this level. Consider, also, that groups displaying nonworking group behaviors may be working but in less overt or easily recognizable ways. Change does not happen at the same pace or in the same manner for members or for groups. Some members may be ready and willing to dive in during the working stage, whereas other members may need to continue to work to build trust. It is important for leaders to recognize that members are moving in the direction of the change they want for themselves. Sometimes working hard to resist the change is a necessary step in a member's process. An effective leader will use all of the "working" and "nonworking" behaviors in a group as grist for the mill.

Working Group	Nonworking Group
Members trust other members and the leaders, or at least they openly express any lack of trust. There is a willingness to take risks by sharing meaningful here-and-now reactions.	Mistrust is evidenced by an undercurrent of unexpressed hostility. Members withhold themselves, refusing to express feelings and thoughts.
Goals are clear and specific and are determined jointly by the members and the leader. There is a willingness to direct group behavior toward realizing these goals.	Goals are fuzzy, abstract, and general. Members have unclear personal goals or no goals at all.

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Working Group	Nonworking Group *(continued)*
Most members feel a sense of inclusion, and excluded members are invited to become more active. Communication among most members is open and involves accurate expression of what is being experienced.	Many members feel excluded or cannot identify with other members. Cliques are formed that tend to lead to fragmentation. There is fear of expressing feelings of being left out. There is a tendency to form subgroups and alliances.
There is a focus on the here and now, and participants talk directly to one another about what they are experiencing.	People tend to focus on others and not on themselves, and storytelling is typical. Members are unwilling to deal with their reactions to one another.
People feel free to bring themselves into the work of others. They do not wait for permission from the leader.	Members lean on the leaders for all direction. There are power conflicts among members as well as between members and the leader.
There is a willingness to risk disclosing threatening material; people become known.	Participants hold back, and disclosure is at a minimum.
Cohesion is high; there is a close emotional bond among members based on sharing universal human experiences. Members identify with one another and are willing to risk new and experimental behavior because of the closeness and support for new ways of being.	Fragmentation exists; members feel distant from one another. There is a lack of caring or empathy. Members do not encourage one another to engage in new and risky behavior, so familiar ways of being are rigidly maintained.
Conflict among members or with the leader is recognized, discussed, and most often resolved.	Conflicts or negative reactions are ignored, denied, or avoided.
Members accept responsibility for deciding what action they will take to solve their problems.	Members blame others for their personal difficulties and are not willing to take action to change.
Feedback is given freely and accepted without defensiveness. There is a willingness to seriously reflect on the accuracy of the feedback.	What little feedback is given is rejected defensively. Feedback is given without care or compassion.
Members feel hopeful; they feel that constructive change is possible—that people can become what they want to become.	Members feel despairing, helpless, trapped, and victimized.
Confrontation occurs in such a way that the confronter shares his or her reactions to the person being confronted. Confrontation is accepted as a challenge to examine one's behavior and not as an uncaring attack.	Confrontation is done in a hostile, attacking way; the confronted one feels judged and rejected. At times the members gang up on a member, using this person as a scapegoat.

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Working Group	Nonworking Group *(continued)*
Communication is clear and direct. There is a minimum of judgments and a maximum of respectful discourse.	Communication is unclear and indirect.
Group members use one another as resources and show interest in one another.	Members are interested mostly in themselves.
Members feel good about themselves and others. They feel a sense of power with one another.	Members do not appreciate themselves or others.
There is an awareness of group process, and members know what makes the group function effectively.	Indifference or lack of awareness of what is going on within the group is common, and group dynamics are rarely discussed.
Issues of diversity, power, and privilege are addressed; there is a respect for individual and cultural differences.	Conformity is prized, and individual and cultural differences are devalued. Members are disrespectful to those who are different from themselves and defensive when discussing issues of power and privilege.
Group norms are developed cooperatively by the members and the leader. Norms are clear and are designed to help the members attain their goals.	Norms are imposed by the leader without the input of members. These norms may not be clear.
There is an emphasis on combining the feeling and thinking functions. Catharsis and expression of feeling occur, but so does thinking about the meaning of various emotional experiences.	The group reinforces the expression of feelings, but with little emphasis on integrating insights with emotional expression.
Group members use out-of-group time to work on problems raised in the group.	Group members think about group activity very little when they are outside the group.

Deepening Trust During the Working Stage

Safety within a group can become an issue even at a later stage of its development, and trust may need to be reestablished. Some members may close off and withdraw because intensive work threatens them, they have doubts about the validity of what they have experienced, they have second thoughts about how involved they want to remain, they are frightened by the display of conflict between members or the expression of painful experiences, or they are anticipating the eventual ending of the group and are prematurely winding down.

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The reality of the changing character of trust within a group is illustrated in this example of an adolescent group. Members had done some productive work, both with individuals outside of the group and with one another during the sessions. At one previous meeting, several members experienced intense emotional catharsis. Felix, who had initially identified his worst fear as "breaking down and crying in front of everyone," did cry and released some repressed pain over being denied his father's acceptance. In role playing with his "father," Felix became angry and told him how hurt he felt because of his seeming indifference. Later in this scenario, he cried and told his "father" that he really loved him. Before he left the session, Felix said that he felt relieved.

The session just described was characterized by a high level of trust, risk-taking, caring, and cohesion. At the next session, however, the group leader was surprised at how difficult it was to draw people out. Members were hesitant to speak. Felix said very little. The leader described what she saw in the room and asked the members what made it so hard to talk, especially in light of the fact that the previous session had gone so well. Several members expressed annoyance, making comments such as these: "Do we always have to bring up problems?" "Do we need to cry to show that we're good members?" "I think you're pushing people too hard." Felix finally admitted that he had felt very embarrassed over "breaking down" and that during the week he had convinced himself that the other group members saw him as weak and foolish. He added that in his culture men never show their tears in public. Some others admitted that although they saw value in what Felix had done they would not want to go through what he had out of fear of what others might think of them. Again, the task of this group was to deal with the lack of trust that members had in one another ("I'm afraid of what others will think of me"). Several of the members' statements implied a lack of trust in the leader, which made it imperative that she encourage the members to discuss this dynamic.

In retrospect, what could the leader have done differently? It is possible that Felix might have felt less embarrassed had the leader remembered his original fear and dealt with it, and also checked out some possible cultural injunctions against public display of emotions. She might have said: "Felix, I remember that one of your fears was crying in the presence of others. You just did. How was it for you to have done this?" She could also have invited others to tell him how they had been affected by his work. Assume that Felix had said: "I feel good, and I got a lot from what I did." Then the leader might have replied: "Imagine two days from now, when you think about what you did this morning. What do you imagine you might think, feel, or say to yourself?" Felix might say: "I am likely to be critical of what I did here." The leader could then suggest that if he catches himself discounting his work it would be helpful to remember the support he felt from everyone in the room and how they had acknowledged his courage.

On the other hand, assume that Felix had responded to the leader's inquiry by saying "I feel embarrassed" while looking down at the floor. She might have replied: "I know how hard it was for you to express yourself in this way. I really hope you won't run away. Would you be willing to look at different people in this room, especially the ones whom you feel most embarrassed with? What do you imagine they're saying about you right now?" After Felix told others what

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he imagined they were thinking of him, they could be invited to give their honest reactions. Typically, members do not make disparaging remarks after someone has done significant work. As this example shows, it is not uncommon for the issue of trust to resurface in an intense and productive session. After times like this, members may be frightened and may have a tendency to retreat. Leaders who are aware of this tendency can take some preventive measures, as we have described. When a group does appear to regress, the most critical intervention is for the leader to describe what is happening and to get members to put to words what they are observing, thinking, and feeling.

Critical Incident

LO5

Conflict With a Cultural Twist

1. Description of Incident

Nadine, a female White leader, facilitated a racially and ethnically diverse adult therapy group of 10 people. The group was to meet for 12 weeks, and this was their 8th meeting. The group was highly cohesive, trusting, willing to give and receive feedback, and highly motivated. Not only did they work well together in the group, but they also applied what they were learning in the group to their outside life. Nadine was surprised when she noticed tension between two group members. Nicole, an African American woman, talked about her conflict with her partner. Beth, a White woman, said under her breath, "Not that again." Nicole overheard the comment and told Beth that this comment really upset her. In a dismissive manner, Beth told Nicole that she was being "too sensitive." In a slightly raised voice, Nicole continued to let Beth know how upsetting her comments were to her. Beth told Nicole to stop shouting and to calm down, which resulted in Nicole becoming even more frustrated. With a look of pain in her eyes, Nicole asked Beth, "Why is it that if I raise my voice a little, you accuse me of shouting?" Beth became very quiet, teared up, got out of her seat, and made a move to leave the room. The other members fell silent. The group leader strongly encouraged both Nicole and Beth to continue to explore their conflict within the group.

2. Process Questions for Group Leaders

1. What are the key issues in this scenario that initially stand out for you? (Think about the clinical issues and the cultural issues.)
2. What cultural factors are at play in how Nicole's raised voice is perceived by Beth? How would you facilitate the discussion around these issues?
3. As the leader, where would you focus your attention? On yourself and your discomfort with this conflict? Concern for the other group members? Concern for Beth and Nicole?
4. What interventions would you make with Nicole and why?
5. What interventions would you make with Beth and why?
6. What are your thoughts about the shift in the level of group cohesion illustrated by this conflict?
7. As the group leader, what feelings might this scenario trigger for you?
8. How might you intervene with Beth as she attempted to leave the room?
9. How would you address the silence in the group?
10. How would you address group members who may intervene and side with or rescue Beth or Nicole?

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3. Clinical Reflections

We need to recognize that conflicts can emerge even in a cohesive and trusting group. Nadine was aware that Beth and Nicole had done some significant work in the group and that they were friends outside of the group. Nadine had a hunch that Beth's dismissive comment to Nicole was even more hurtful because they had an outside friendship. Nadine's primary goals were to facilitate their interaction so neither of them shut down and to assess the impact of the conflict on the other group members. Although the situation was uncomfortable, Nadine wanted to help the group deal with this conflict.

The leader was surprised by the sudden intensity of this situation and realized that Beth had triggered a cultural stereotype in Nicole. In a conflict between members, the goal of the leader is to take the side of the relationship, not the side of one person over the other. For the group to trust the leader, Nadine needs to show a willingness to address the conflict rather than trying to smooth it over too quickly. The members also need to make a commitment to talk about their reactions to the conflict and how they are affected by it. Trust is unlikely to be reestablished if members avoid dealing with uncomfortable situations such as this one. There were several layers of conflict in this scenario, but this was also a teachable moment. Nadine could help to bring about an honest discussion involving culture and styles of communication. If she avoids the topic, some members may feel misunderstood and marginalized.

4. Possible Interventions

1. The leader can ask both Nicole and Beth how they were affected by each other's reactions and comments.
2. The leader might want to facilitate a process in which Nicole is able to express her frustrations as an African American in communicating with White people.
3. The leader could check in with all of the members so they can express how they felt as they witnessed the conflict between Nicole and Beth.
4. Because Nadine is White, she could ask Nicole if she has reactions to her as a leader.
5. The leader can model cultural responsiveness by talking out loud about what she observes occurring between Nicole and Beth and how cultural stereotypes may be at play.
6. With tears in her eyes, Beth was set to leave the room. The leader could ask Beth to talk to Nicole about what was evoked in her and what prompted her to want to leave.
7. The leader could ask the group to explore the various ways their culture influences their expression of pain. For example, in one group tears may be common and in another anger may feel like a safer way to show vulnerability.
8. The leader could explore possible transference reactions after facilitating the here-and-now conflict. Assume that the leader knew from prior sessions that Beth had an angry and abusive father and that Nicole had been taught it is best to avoid challenging White people. The leader could explore deeper issues with both Nicole and Beth that could account for their reactions to each other.

Choices to Be Made During the Working Stage

LO6

In discussing the initial stages of a group's evolution, we described several critical issues, such as trust versus mistrust, the struggle for power, and self-focus versus focus on others. During the more intense working period of a group, key issues at stake include disclosure versus anonymity, authenticity versus guardedness, spontaneity versus control, acceptance versus rejection, and unity versus fragmentation. A group's identity is shaped by the way its members resolve these critical issues.

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Disclosure Versus Anonymity Members can decide to disclose themselves in a significant and appropriate way, or they can choose to remain hidden out of fear. People may protect themselves through anonymity, yet the very reason many become involved in a therapeutic group is because they want to make themselves known to others and to come to know others and themselves in a deeper way. If the group process is to work effectively, members need to share meaningful dimensions of themselves, for it is through self-disclosure that others come to know them.

Authenticity Versus Guardedness It is fundamental to the success of a therapeutic group that authenticity prevail and that members do not feel they have to disguise or hide their true selves to be accepted. Genuine intimacy is not possible when people remain unknown or when they feel compelled to guard their true feelings. Members may present themselves in less then genuine ways for a variety of reasons. Sometimes people hide parts of themselves out of a fear of rejection; others may wear masks in certain settings because of their experience with racism and other forms of discrimination.

Genuine intimacy is not possible when people remain unknown or when they feel compelled to guard their true feelings.

Spontaneity Versus Control We expect group participants to make the choice to relinquish some of their controlled and rehearsed ways and allow themselves to respond more spontaneously to events of the moment. We encourage members to "rehearse out loud" so that both they and others get a glimpse of their internal processing. Spontaneity can be fostered indirectly by helping clients feel that it is all right to say and do many of the things they have been preventing themselves from saying or doing. This does not mean that members "do their own thing" at the expense of others. Members sometimes stifle themselves by endlessly rehearsing everything they say. As a result, they often sit quietly and rehearse internally. We generally make contracts with clients like this, asking them to agree to rehearse out loud and to speak more freely, even at the risk of not making sense. We encourage them to try out unrehearsed behavior in the group setting, and then they can decide which aspects of their behavior they may want to change away from the group.

Acceptance Versus Rejection Throughout the course of a group, the members frequently deal with the acceptance–rejection polarity. We sometimes hear a member say, "I'd like to be myself, yet I'm afraid that if I'm me, I'll not be accepted. I worry about this because I often feel that I really don't fit into the group." The basis of this fear can be explored, which most often results in challenging fears without foundation. Members are likely to find that they reject themselves more often than others reject them. These members may also discover that they are frightened about the prospects of being accepted as well as of being rejected. Although they do not enjoy rejection, it has become a familiar feeling, and feelings of acceptance can be unsettling: "If you accept me or love me or care for me, I won't know how to respond."

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The group setting provides opportunities for members to learn some of the ways in which they are setting themselves up to be rejected by behaving in a certain manner. As group members begin to recognize their own role and responsibility in the creation of an accepting or rejecting climate, they come to understand that their own behavior helps to determine whether they as individuals will be accepted or rejected.

Lara struggled with whether to disclose her eating disorder to the group. No other members have raised this topic, and Lara is fearful that if others know they will judge her or be disgusted by her eating disorder behaviors. When she shared her struggles with someone outside the group, that person told Lara that she needed to exert more willpower over food and her urge to binge and purge. Lara has convinced herself that it is best not to share her problems with anyone.

As the leaders work with Lara on how she is holding herself back in the group, she begins to express her fear of exposing herself more intimately to the group. The leaders encourage Lara to talk more about the response she expects to get from members without telling the group what the specific issue is. Lara's willingness to be honest led her to have a different experience than she had anticipated, which helped her to begin to build trust with the other group members.

Unity Versus Fragmentation Unity is largely the result of the group's choice to work actively at developing a sense of community and establishing bonds with each other. Members achieve this sense of community mainly by choosing to make themselves known to others, by sharing their pain, by allowing caring to develop, by initiating meaningful conversation, and by giving honest feedback to others. A unified group comes from working with members' meaningful, painful realities as well as from intimately sharing humorous and joyous moments.

If a group makes a decision to remain comfortable or to stay with superficial interactions, there will be little group togetherness. There are times when members choose not to express their fears, suspicions, disappointments, and doubts. When members conceal their reactions, fragmentation and lack of trust typically result. When some members meet outside the group or form cliques and gossip about the leader or other members, the level of trust within a group can be eroded. This kind of subgrouping can represent a powerful hidden agenda that will continue to block meaningful interchanges. The behavior of this subgroup needs to be recognized and discussed with the entire group for this fragmentation to be repaired.

Not all meetings outside of the group are necessarily damaging to a unified group. Certain kinds of subgroupings can be beneficial. For example, in a residential facility, inpatient group members may meet outside of the group to participate in a range of activities to gain practice in working together on projects or participating in recreational activities. These kinds of subgroups are not meant to exclude others but to give members further opportunities to interact with others in the treatment facility. Another example of potentially beneficial meetings in subgroups can be found in the weeklong residential personal-growth groups that we (Marianne and Jerry) organized for 25 years each summer. These groups consisted of 16 members and 4 group leaders. We met with the entire group each day, yet each day we also met in small groups (of 8 members and 2 leaders). In addition, free time each day provided members with the opportunity to participate in

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various activities with different people. These informal get-togethers often stimulated therapeutic work that the members brought back to the group.

Homework During the Working Stage

The group is not an end in itself. Members may learn new behaviors and acquire a range of skills in living during group sessions, but members need to practice these skills and behaviors outside of the group. Members can be encouraged to devise their own homework assignments, ideally at each of the group sessions. Homework maximizes what is learned in the group and translates this learning to many different situations in daily life. If members are willing to create homework and follow through with it, their motivation and the overall level of cohesion in the group will increase.

Although we often suggest an activity for members to consider doing outside of the group, we avoid being prescriptive and telling members what they should do for homework. We encourage group members to keep a journal, and these writings can be a catalyst for them to engage in new behavior within the group. Our suggestions for homework are presented in the spirit of assisting members in increasing their chances to get what they say they want from the group experience. Homework is especially useful at this stage of a group because it provides encouragement and direction for members to practice actual skills they are learning in the group. Homework often helps members translate their insights into action plans aimed at change. As much as possible, homework is best designed collaboratively with group members. Homework is a basic part of all of the cognitive behavioral approaches, but it is an appropriate technique for use in groups that are structured with other theoretical frameworks as well. See Chapter 4 for specific theories that make use of homework.

Oftentimes members do intense exploration of their significant relationships in group sessions. Although talking about a relationship can be therapeutic and members may gain insights into the dynamics of the relationship, this is only the beginning of change. Members then can decide whether they are interested in talking differently to this person in their life. For example, Rosa decides on the following homework. She wants to approach her mother in a different manner than she typically does—without arguing and getting defensive. First in the group she practices what she wants to express to her mother. She receives feedback and support from other members regarding her symbolic interaction with her mother in this way. When Rosa clearly understands what she wants with her mother based on her behavioral rehearsal in the group, she will be better prepared to behave differently with her mother. Group practice and homework can often be combined in this way to help members make important changes in their everyday lives.

LO7

Therapeutic Factors That Operate in a Group

A variety of forces within groups can be healing, or therapeutic, and these forces play a key role in producing constructive changes. The **therapeutic factors** discussed in this section operate to differing degrees in all stages of a group, but

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they are most often manifested during the working stage. The therapeutic factors discussed here reflect our experiences in leading groups and the reports of the many people who have participated in our groups. (In many of our groups, we ask participants to write follow-up reaction papers describing what factors facilitated their changes in attitudes and behavior.) We are particularly indebted to Irvin Yalom (2005b) for his pioneering work in identifying therapeutic factors in therapy groups.

Self-Disclosure and the Group Member

LO8

The willingness to make oneself known to others is part of each stage of a group, but at the working stage self-disclosure is more frequent and more personal. Members are expected to self-disclose in a group, and the leader needs to teach and to facilitate member self-disclosure. Although a norm of member self-disclosure is desirable, clinical findings do not support the idea that more disclosure is always better. Too much or too little disclosure can be counterproductive, and leaders should monitor such disclosures so a single member does not lead the others by too great a gap in terms of frequency and depth of disclosure (Yalom, 2005b). Although disclosure is not an end in itself, it is the means by which open communication occurs within the group.

Group members are able to deepen their self-knowledge through disclosing themselves to others. Members develop a richer and more integrated picture of who they are, and they are better able to recognize the impact they have on others. Through this process, the participants experience a healing force and gain new insights that often lead to desired life changes. If disclosures are limited to safe topics, the group does not progress beyond a superficial level.

We tell our group members that it is essential to let others know about them, especially as it pertains to their experience of being in the group. Otherwise, they are likely to be misunderstood because people tend to project their own feelings onto members who keep themselves unknown. For example, Andrea thinks that Walter is very critical of her. When Walter finally talks, he discloses that he is both attracted to and fearful of Andrea. Walter can be asked to share what it was like for him to admit this to Andrea. Self-disclosure entails revealing current struggles with unresolved personal issues; goals and aspirations; fears and expectations; hopes, pains, and joys; strengths and weaknesses; and personal experiences. If members keep themselves anonymous and say little about themselves that is personal, it is difficult for others to care for them. Genuine concern comes from knowledge of the person. As you can see, this disclosure is not limited simply to revealing personal concerns; it is equally important to disclose ongoing persistent reactions toward other members and the leader.

In leading groups, you cannot apply the same criteria in assessing the value of self-disclosure for all members equally. Differences exist among people due to variables such as cultural background, sexual orientation, and age. For example, an older woman who has never publicly talked about some personal aspects of her marriage may be taking large steps in even approaching this subject. Respect the risks she is taking, and avoid comparing her with members who self-disclose freely. A woman who discloses for the first time that she is lesbian may experience

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self-doubts due to internalized homophobia. The leader needs to be attentive to any possible afterthoughts or regrets the member may have for sharing, as well as any negative reactions the group may have toward the member who disclosed her sexual identity. Even if this is not the first time she has disclosed that she is lesbian, the leader will most likely want to ask what it was like for her to make this disclosure in this new group of people.

The cultural context also needs to be considered in what you might expect in terms of self-disclosure from some members. For example, it may be overwhelming and frightening if you were to ask a recent immigrant to participate in an exercise in which members are exploring conflicts with their parents. He may consider any discussion pertaining to his family as shaming or betraying them. In all of these examples, it is important to explore how the members can meaningfully participate in a way that enables them to reach their goals in this group.

What Disclosure Is Not Group participants frequently misunderstand what it means to self-disclose, equating disclosure with keeping nothing private and saying too much. By displaying hidden secrets to the group, members may feel that they are disclosing useful information, which is often not the case. Those who participate in a group need to learn the difference between appropriate and inappropriate self-disclosure. Here are some observations on what self-disclosure is *not*:

- Self-disclosure is not merely telling stories about one's past in a rehearsed and mechanical manner. It is not a mere reporting of there-and-then events. A client needs to ask the question, "How is what I reveal related to my present conflicts?"
- In the name of being open and honest and as a result of the pressure of other group members, people often say more than is necessary for others to understand them. They confuse being self-disclosing with being open to the extent that nothing remains private. As a result, they may feel overly exposed in front of others.
- Expressing every fleeting feeling or reaction to others is not to be confused with self-disclosure. Judgment is needed in deciding how appropriate it is to share certain reactions. Persistent reactions are generally best shared, but people can be honest without being tactless and insensitive.

Guidelines for Appropriate Member Self-Disclosure In our groups we suggest the following guidelines as a way of assisting participants in determining *what* to disclose and *when* self-disclosure is both appropriate and facilitative:

- The degree of self-disclosure should be related to the purposes, goals, and type of the group.
- If members have persistent reactions to certain people in the group, members are encouraged to bring them out into the open without blaming, especially when these reactions are inhibiting their level of participation.
- Members must determine *what* and *how much* they want others to know about them. They also have to decide what they are willing to risk and how far they are willing to go.

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- Reasonable risks can be expected to accompany self-disclosure. If groups are restricted to overly safe disclosures, the interactions can become fairly meaningless.
- The stage of group development has some bearing on the appropriateness of self-disclosure. Certain disclosures may be too deep for an initial session but quite appropriate during the working stage.

Related to the issue of member self-disclosure is the role of leader self-disclosure. We now turn to some guidelines designed to assist leaders in thinking about how their disclosures can have a facilitative effect on a group.

Self-Disclosure and the Group Leader

LO9

Leaders who self-disclose do so for a variety of reasons. The key question is not whether leaders should disclose themselves to the group but, rather, *how much, when,* and *for what purpose.* Appropriate leader self-disclosure can be used to model risk-taking and may be a key element in joining and building trust. Leader self-disclosures pose some risks, but skilled clinicians can use even a disclosure gone awry to facilitate a useful discussion with group members. Sometimes the decision to disclose is thought out by the leader ahead of time; other times it is a more spontaneous contribution either because it feels right for the moment or because a member has asked the leader a direct question of a personal nature.

Some group leaders are careful not to make themselves personally known to the group, striving to keep their personal involvement in the group to a minimum. Some do this because of a theoretical preference, such as psychoanalytically oriented group therapists who view their role as that of a "transference figure" on whom group members can project feelings they have experienced toward parents and other significant people in their lives. By remaining anonymous, the leader encourages members' projections from an earlier relationship. When these unresolved conflicts are exposed, they can be worked through within the group. Group counselors with an experiential and relationship orientation are likely to make therapeutic use of self-disclosure as a way to involve themselves more fully in a group. Person-centered group facilitators, existential therapists, and Gestalt therapists tend to employ self-disclosure to deepen the trust between members and leader and to provide modeling.

Some members come from cultural backgrounds in which trust requires some personal knowledge of the other person. Sharing life experiences and identity issues has helped us to join with members who are very different from us, and members have said that this sharing helped them to feel more trusting toward us. On occasion we share a reaction or feelings we are having because not doing so will keep us distant from the group and therefore interrupt their process. When a member asks for specific personal information, the leader should try to understand why this is important to the member. By responding too quickly to a request for self-disclosure, the leader may miss an opportunity to learn more about what is truly important to that member. Disclosures are best used to promote members' self-understanding.

Group leaders sometimes engage in too much self-disclosure, blurring the boundaries and becoming personally involved in the group they are responsible

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for facilitating. Avoid submitting to group pressure to cease being a leader and becoming more of a group member. Even though group leaders can participate in personal ways at times, their primary role in the group is to initiate, facilitate, direct, and evaluate the process of interaction among members. Leader self-disclosures should be appropriate, timely, helpful, purposeful, and done for the good of the group members. As a group leader, ask yourself, "How will what I'm about to say be therapeutic or useful to the group members?" Group leaders should be able to support their self-disclosure on theoretical grounds. Group leaders need to accurately assess their own motivations for engaging in self-disclosure and the impact such disclosures will have on individual group members and the group as a whole.

Leader self-disclosures should be appropriate, timely, helpful, purposeful, and done for the good of the group members.

Beginning counselors tend to misjudge the use of leader self-disclosure. Sometimes the desire to self-disclose stems from a need to be liked by group members rather than being a tool for facilitating the process of the group. Self-disclosing too readily can blur boundaries and, in some cases, undermine the leader's perceived competence. Yalom (2005b) stresses that leader self-disclosure must be instrumental in helping the *members* attain their goals. He calls for selective therapist disclosure that provides members with acceptance, support, and encouragement. Group leaders who disclose here-and-now reactions rather than detailed personal events from their past tend to facilitate the movement of the group.

There have been times when I (Marianne) have disclosed something personal that was preventing me from being fully present with the group. I find that trying to hide my distractions or my inability to listen results in a disconnection, which group members may personalize. On one occasion, this resulted in some members' hesitation to work with their problems because they wanted to take care of me and did not want to burden me with their pain. When I noticed this, I let the group know that simply sharing my present experience was what I needed to make myself available to them. My guideline for self-disclosure can be summed up as follows: When something is so much in the foreground that it distracts me from being present and available to the members, I am likely to acknowledge this in a brief way without burdening the group with details.

There is no steadfast rule as to when a leader should or should not self-disclose. In general, the more experience we gain with facilitating groups, the better we are at determining the moments when self-disclosure may be beneficial for members. Although disclosure may be appropriate in the advanced stages of a group, sharing it initially may burden the participants with the feeling that they should help you or should take your pain away. In leading a group for incest survivors, most members were relieved that the leaders did not disclose whether they had or had not been incest survivors themselves. Most members felt they would have been protective of the leaders if they knew the leaders were incest survivors, and this would have limited members' ability to lean on the leaders for support. One member felt that knowing more about the leaders would have helped her to feel more trusting of them.

Timing and considering the population of your group are crucial in doing what is compatible with your personal therapeutic style. It is important to realize

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that some group members may respond with embarrassment and discomfort over a leader's self-disclosure, especially if they view the leader as an expert. Certain leader self-disclosures, such as sharing performance anxiety, could diminish members' perceptions about a leader's competence and thus impede establishing trust.

The decision to self-disclose should be based on your theoretical orientation, your clinical intuition, and the potential benefit to the member(s). A question we might ask is, "Whom does this disclosure serve?" Consider the following four guidelines in determining your own position on the issue of leader self-disclosure:

1. If you determine that you have problems you wish to explore, consider finding your own therapeutic group. This would allow you to be a participating member without the concern of how your personal work would affect the group. You have a demanding job and should not make it even more difficult by confusing your role with that of the participants.
2. Ask yourself why you are disclosing certain personal material. Is it to be seen as a "regular person," no different from the members? Is it to model disclosing behavior for others? Is it because you genuinely want to show private dimensions to the members? It may be therapeutic for group members to know you and your struggles, but they do not need to know them in elaborate detail. For instance, if a member is exploring her fear of not being loved unless she is perfect, you might reveal in a few words that you also wrestle with this fear, if indeed you do. Your sharing makes it possible for your client to feel a sense of identification with you. At another time it may be appropriate for you to talk a bit more.
3. Disclosure that is related to what is going on in the group is the most productive. For instance, any persistent feelings you have about a member or about what is happening (or not happening) are generally best revealed. If you are being affected by a member's behavior, it is usually advisable to let the member know your reaction. If you sense a general reluctance in the group, it is best to talk openly about the cautiousness and about how it feels to experience it. Disclosure related to how you feel in the group is generally more appropriate than disclosure of personal material that is not relevant to the ongoing interaction of the group.
4. Ask yourself how much you want to reveal about your private life to the many people with whom you will come into contact. In our workshops, other groups, and classes we want to feel the freedom to function openly as people, but at the same time we want to preserve a measure of our privacy. Moreover, if we always gave detailed accounts about ourselves, we would lose spontaneity. It is impossible to maintain a fresh and unrehearsed style with such repetition.

Discussing the role and purpose of leader self-disclosure with members can be useful whether the leader discloses or does not. Take time to reflect on your guidelines for determining when self-disclosure is appropriate and furthers interaction within the group. Address these questions as a way to formulate your views of leader self-disclosure:

- How willing are you to share aspects of your personal life if members ask you questions?

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- How can you decide if revealing aspects of yourself would be helpful to members?
- Do you consider it important to disclose what you are experiencing if you are being triggered by the work of certain members?
- How open would you want to be in letting members know of your ongoing reactions to what is happening within the group?
- If you are having difficulty with a group member, are you willing to let this member know how you are being affected?

Feedback

LO10

One of the most important ways learning takes place in a group is through a combination of member self-disclosure and group feedback. This often leads to deeper levels of intimacy in the group. Interpersonal feedback influences the development of many therapeutic factors. **Feedback** occurs when group members or leaders share their observations and personal reactions regarding the behavior of another. Feedback has been associated with increased motivation for change, greater insight into how one's behavior affects others, increased willingness to take risks, and group members evaluating their group experience more positively. When feedback is given honestly and with sensitivity, members are able to understand the impact they have on others and decide what, if anything, they want to change about their interpersonal style. Through a process of feedback exchange, members have opportunities to view their interpersonal style from new perspectives and are able to make meaningful changes in their behavior (Stockton, Morran, & Chang, 2014). The process of interpersonal feedback encourages members to accept responsibility for the outcomes of a group and for changing the style in which they relate to others.

Like self-disclosure, group leaders need to teach participants how to give and receive feedback. Leaders do well to model effective delivery of feedback and to encourage members to engage in thoughtful feedback exchange (Stockton et al., 2014). In cognitive behavioral groups, members are given specific instructions about what kind of feedback is helpful and how to best receive feedback from others. For members (or leaders) to benefit from feedback, it is critical that they be willing to listen to the reactions and comments others offer. Members are more likely to consider feedback that may be difficult to hear when there is a balance between positive or supportive feedback and corrective or challenging feedback (sometimes referred to as "negative" feedback), and when a level of trust has been established. Members can gain from feedback that is given in a clear, caring, genuine, and personal manner.

Members can gain from feedback that is given in a clear, caring, genuine, and personal manner.

Feedback as a process in groups is given further consideration in Chapter 9, but effective feedback is an important component of the working stage. Here are some guidelines we use for teaching members about effective feedback during the working stage:

- Clear and concise feedback is more helpful than statements with qualifiers. For instance, Lilia is being quite clear and direct with Brad when she tells him:

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"I feel uncomfortable when I'm sharing very personal things about myself and I see you smiling. It makes me wonder if you're taking me seriously."

- In offering feedback to other group members, share with them how they affect you rather than giving them advice or judging them. In the preceding example, Lilia is speaking about her own discomfort and how she is affected by Brad's smiling, rather than calling Brad insensitive. This is what makes this feedback challenging, rather than negative.
- Specific here-and-now feedback that pertains to behavior in the group is especially useful. Lilia's comments to Brad addressed how his behavior was affecting her. If Lilia does not speak up now, her discomfort may continue to increase until she reacts at a time when her statements are out of context.
- Feedback that is given in a timely and nonjudgmental way increases the chances that the person receiving it will reflect on this information. In Lilia's case, her feedback to Brad is focused on her personal reactions and how she is affected, and it represents a risky self-disclosure.
- Feedback that pertains to the interpersonal relationship can be powerful. For instance, in giving feedback to Brad, Lilia might add: "I want to feel closer to you. But I'm careful of what I say when I'm around you because I don't know what you are thinking. When you look away and either smile or frown when I talk, I'm left wondering how what I'm saying affects you. I do want to be able to trust you more." With this kind of statement, Lilia is talking about her feelings of fear and uncertainty, but she is also letting Brad know that she would like a different kind of relationship with him.
- Addressing a person's strengths rather than concentrating exclusively on the difficulties you are experiencing with this person can improve reactions to that feedback. For example, a leader might say to a member who is getting lost in the details of her story: "I'm glad you spoke up. I did have some difficulty following your story and staying focused because you were talking more about others than about yourself. However, I do have a better understanding of your struggle now, and I hope you strive to keep focused on your own experience."

Members sometimes make a sweeping declaration, spontaneously asking the group for feedback and putting other members on the spot. Here is an example that typifies this approach:

EXAMPLE: Fernando says, "I'd like to know what you think of me, and I'd like some feedback!" If we were to hear this, we would probably say to the group, "Before anyone gives you feedback Fernando, we'd like you to say more about what prompted you to ask for these reactions." This intervention requires that Fernando make significant disclosures about himself before insisting that others disclose themselves to him. Members are more likely to respond to him when they know more about his need for their feedback. Behind his question may well be any of these statements: "I'm afraid, and I don't know if I'm liked." "I'm afraid people are judging me." "I don't have many friends in my life, and it's important that these people like me."

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If Fernando has said very little about himself, it is difficult to give him many reactions. To find out how others perceive him, it is necessary that he let himself be known. After he has explored his need for feedback, the group leader can ask members if they want to react to him. However, the leader should not pressure everyone in the group to give him their comments. When people do offer their reactions, the leader can ask Fernando to listen attentively, to hear what others have to say to him, and to consider what, if anything, he may want to do with this information.

As the group progresses to a working stage, we typically see a willingness of members to freely give one another their reactions. The norm of asking for, receiving, and giving feedback needs to be established early in a group. Furthermore, it is the leader's task to teach members how to give useful feedback. Feedback is at its best when members spontaneously let others know how they are affected by them and their work. For example, a member might say, "I was very affected by the way you role-played talking to your mother; it reminds me of the difficulty I have in feeling understood by my mother." This kind of feedback connects members to each other through similar struggles. Here is another example of how useful feedback can benefit a member:

> **EXAMPLE:** Chan joined a group because he found himself isolated from people. Soon he found that he felt isolated in the group also. He was sarcastic in his group, a trait that quickly alienated others. Because the members were willing to tell him in a caring way that they felt put off and distanced by his sarcastic style, he was able to examine and eventually assume responsibility for creating the distance and lack of intimacy he typically experienced. With the encouragement of his group, he sought out his son, from whom he felt disconnected. When he gave up his sarcasm and talked honestly with his son, he found that his son was willing to listen.

Confrontation

As was discussed in Chapters 6 and 7, constructive confrontation is a form of feedback that is a basic part of a productive group, and also of any healthy relationship. It is through acts of caring and respectful confrontation that members are invited to examine discrepancies between what they say and do, to become aware of potentials that are dormant, and to find ways of putting their insights into action. Sensitive confrontation by others helps members develop the capacity for self-confrontation, a skill they will need in applying what they have learned to the problems they face in their daily lives. This kind of feedback can result in sustained behavior change.

> **EXAMPLE:** Alexander complained of feeling tired and drained. He asserted that everyone in his life was demanding. In the group his style of interacting involved being a helper. He was attentive to what others needed, yet he rarely asked anything for himself. In one session he finally admitted that he was not

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getting what he wanted from the group and that he did not feel like returning again. The leader confronted Alexander: "I have seen you do many times in this group what you say you typically do with people in your life. I see you as being very helpful, yet you rarely ask for anything for yourself. I'm not surprised about your reluctance over coming back to the group. You've created the same environment in here as the one at home. I'm glad you're seeing this. Is this something you are willing to change?"

Cohesion and Universality

Group cohesion is a norm for the early phase of a group (see Chapter 6), and we return to this topic now because group cohesion is also a therapeutic factor in an effective working group, providing a climate in which members feel free to do meaningful work. Characteristics of a cohesive group include a climate of support, bonding, sharing of experiences, mutuality within the group, a sense of belonging, warmth and closeness, and caring and acceptance. Members' willingness to let others know them in meaningful ways deepens the level of trust, which allows for increased cohesion.

Group cohesion fosters action-oriented behaviors such as self-disclosure, giving and receiving feedback, discussion of here-and-now interactions, the constructive expression of conflicts in the group, a willingness to take risks, and translating insight into action. Cohesion is necessary for effective group work, but it is not a sufficient condition. Some groups choose to stop at the level of comfort and security and do not push ahead to new levels. Other groups reach an impasse because members are unwilling to have meaningful interactions with one another.

Yalom (2005b) maintains that cohesion is related to many positive characteristics within a group. Highly cohesive groups tend to be characterized by better attendance and less turnover. Members of a cohesive group show greater acceptance, intimacy, and understanding; cohesion also helps members recognize and work through conflicts. Members feel free to express anger and deal with conflict if they feel a sense of commitment to the group and if they perceive the group as a safe place. Our experience in facilitating groups has convinced us that cohesion is a valuable concept and that it can be a unifying force for group members. Cohesion operates as a therapeutic factor at first by enhancing group support and acceptance, and later by playing a crucial role in interpersonal learning.

At the working stage, members are able to see commonalities, and they are often struck by the universality of their life issues. For example, our therapeutic groups are composed of a very wide mixture of people. The members come from all walks of life, and they differ in many respects: age, sexual orientation, social and cultural backgrounds, career paths, and level of education. Although in the earlier stages members are likely to be aware of their differences and at times feel separated, as the group achieves increased cohesion, these differences recede into the background. Members comment more on how they are alike than on how they are different. A woman in her early 50s discovers that she is still striving for parental approval, just as is a man in his early 20s. A man learns that his struggles with masculinity are not that different from a woman's concern about her femininity. A woman in a heterosexual relationship discovers that she can relate to a lesbian's

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fear of intimacy in her relationship. Both women are able to connect with each other as they explore their fear of rejection in their relationships.

The circumstances leading to hurt and disappointment may be very different from person to person or from culture to culture, but the resulting emotions have a universal quality. Although we may not speak the same language or come from the same society, we are connected through our feelings of joy and pain. It is when group members no longer get lost in the details of daily experiences and instead share their deeper struggles with these universal human themes that a group is most cohesive. The leader can help the group achieve this level of cohesion by focusing on the underlying issues, feelings, and needs that the members seem to share.

This bonding provides the group with the impetus to move forward, for participants gain courage by discovering that they are not alone in their feelings. A woman experiences a great sense of relief when she discovers, through statements by other women, that she is not alone in feeling resentment over the many demands her family makes on her. Men find that they can share their tears and affection with other men without being robbed of their masculinity. In the proposal for a men's group in a community agency (see Chapter 11), the group provided a place for men to discover universal themes, and by exploring deeply personal concerns the bond among the members was strengthened.

The leader can foster the development of cohesion by pointing out the common themes that unite members of the group. Universal themes include remembering painful experiences of childhood and adolescence, experiencing loneliness and abandonment, becoming aware of the need for and fear of love, learning to express feelings that have been blocked from awareness, searching for meaning in life, recognizing universal themes that link us together as humans, recognizing unfinished business with parents, and seeking meaningful connections with significant people. This list is not exhaustive but merely a sample of the universal human issues that participants recognize and explore with one another as the group progresses, regardless of their sometimes obvious differences. The cohesion that is characteristic of the working stage is a deeper intimacy that develops with sharing by members, time, and commitment. This bonding is a form of affection and genuine caring that often results from sharing the expression of painful experiences.

EXAMPLE: A couple of women, both of whom immigrated to this country, express the pain they feel over having left their own countries. Until this time, they had felt rather isolated from other group members. Sharing their struggle touched just about everyone in the group. Members could identify with their pain and loss even though they did not share the same experiences. The work of these two women was productive for them, but it also stimulated other members to talk about times in their lives when they felt deep loss. During closure of the session, as members made comments about how they were affected by the meeting, they talked about how close they felt and the bond of trust that had developed. Despite having different backgrounds, these group members were brought together by a deeply personal sharing of common themes and feelings.

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Hope

Hope is the belief that change is possible. Some people approach a group convinced that they have absolutely no control of external circumstances. Members who are mandated to attend group may feel extremely hopeless and be convinced that nothing will really change. In the group, however, they may encounter others who have struggled and found ways to assume effective control over their lives. Seeing and being associated with such people can inspire a new sense of optimism that their lives can be different. Hope is therapeutic in itself because it gives members confidence that they have the power to choose to be different, or to change their life circumstances.

People are sometimes so discouraged that they are unable to see any way to change a life situation. Group leaders must guard against being drawn into the hopelessness of such members and continue to approach their groups with a conviction that change and a better outcome are possible. For example, a client of mine (Marianne) worked hard at convincing me that there was no hope for change in her life. One day she exclaimed, "You don't understand. I am *really* hopeless." I let her know that if I felt as hopeless about her as she did, I would not be of much help to her. I empathized with her sense of despair while encouraging her not to give up. A hopeful sign that I saw and she did not was the fact that she was seeking help. A lack of hope may spring from a series of disappointments, injuries, or even abuses, but it serves to keep people stuck. It is helpful to understand and support members but at the same time challenge them to examine the situation surrounding their hopelessness and despair. We need to understand the function of their lack of hope before we can help them move past it.

> **EXAMPLE:** Travis, a veteran, was left paralyzed as a result of an injury suffered during a war. He spent most of his energy thinking about all that he could no longer do. With the encouragement of his physician, Travis joined a rehabilitation group where he met several other wounded veterans who had at one time felt as he was feeling now. By listening to their struggles and how they had effectively coped with their disabilities, Travis found hope that he, too, could discover more effective ways of living his life.

Willingness to Risk and to Trust

Risking involves opening oneself to others, being vulnerable, and actively doing in a group what is necessary for change. Taking risks requires moving past what is known and secure toward more uncertain terrain. If members are primarily motivated to remain comfortable, or if they are unwilling to risk challenging themselves and others, they stand to gain very little from the group. Members' willingness to reveal themselves is largely a function of how much they trust the other group members and the leader. The higher the level of trust in a group, the more likely members are to push themselves beyond their comfort level. From the outset, members can be invited to risk by talking about their feelings of being in the group. As a few members engage in even minor risk-taking, others will

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follow suit. By taking risks in disclosing here-and-now observations and reactions, members are actively creating trust and making it possible to engage in deeper self-exploration. Trust is a healing agent; it enables people to show the many facets of themselves, encourages experimental behavior, and allows people to look at themselves in new ways.

EXAMPLE: Carmen expressed considerable resentment to the men in her group. Eventually, she took a risk and disclosed that as a child she had been sexually abused by her stepfather. As she explored ways in which she had generalized her distrust of men in everyday life and in her group, she began to see how she was keeping men at a distance so they would never again have the chance to hurt her. This led to a new decision that all men would not necessarily want to hurt her and if they did she could take care of herself. Had she been unwilling to risk making the disclosure in her group, it is unlikely that she would have made this attitudinal and behavioral change.

Caring and Acceptance

Caring is demonstrated by listening and by involvement. It can be expressed by tenderness, compassion, support, and even confrontation. One way caring is demonstrated is by staying present with someone who has received some feedback that was difficult to hear. If members sense a lack of genuine caring, either from other members or from the leader, their willingness to make themselves vulnerable will be limited. Members are able to risk being vulnerable if they sense that their concerns are important to others and that they are valued as people.

Caring implies acceptance, a genuine support from others that says, in effect: "We will accept all of your feelings. You matter to us. It is acceptable to be yourself—you do not have to strive to please everyone." Acceptance involves affirming each person's right to have and express feelings and values.

Caring and acceptance develop into empathy, a deep understanding of another's struggles. Commonalities emerge in groups that unite the members. The realization that certain problems are universal—loneliness, the need for acceptance, the fear of rejection, the fear of intimacy, hurt over past experiences—lessens the feelings that we are alone. Moreover, through identification with others we are able to see ourselves more clearly.

EXAMPLE: In a group for children, Bobby finally began to talk tearfully about his sadness over the loss of his father due to a fatal accident. Other children were very attentive. When Bobby said that he was embarrassed by his crying, two other boys told him that they also cried. This sharing of loneliness and hurt bonded the children. It assured them that what they were feeling was normal.

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Power

A feeling of power emerges from the recognition that one has untapped internal reserves of spontaneity, creativity, courage, and strength. This strength is not a power over others; rather, it is the sense that one has the resources necessary to direct one's own life. In groups personal power is experienced in ways that were formerly denied. Some people enter groups feeling that they are powerless. They become empowered when they realize they can take certain steps in their current situation to make life more rewarding. However, it is crucial for leaders to understand and appreciate the context surrounding the lack of power that some members may experience. This is particularly important for members from marginalized groups who have often been disempowered by various social systems. It is not safe for some individuals to assert newly founded power in every life situation. For example, Alfonso's father may never speak to him again if Alfonso asserts himself by confronting his father. Leaders need to assist members in assessing the potential consequences, as well as when and where it may not be safe to express themselves fully. Here is an example of a member reclaiming a sense of power.

> **EXAMPLE:** As a child, Edith was often hit by her parents if she made herself visible. She made an early decision to keep a low profile to avoid being abused physically and psychologically. Through her participation in a group, she discovered that she was still behaving as if everyone was out to get her, and that her defensive ways were no longer warranted. Because she chose not to make her presence known in her group, people saw her as distant, cold, and aloof. Edith gradually discovered that she was no longer a helpless child who could not protect herself in a cruel adult world. By challenging her assumptions and by taking risks with people in her group, Edith also assumed more power over how she felt about herself and how she allowed herself to be treated by others.

Catharsis

Energy is tied up in withholding threatening feelings. Unexpressed feelings often result in physical symptoms such as chronic headaches, stomach pains, muscle tension, and high blood pressure. At times group members say that they do not want to remember painful feelings, not understanding that the body can be carrying the pain and giving expression to it with various physical symptoms. When people finally do express their stored-up pain and other unexpressed feelings, they typically report a tremendous physical and emotional release, known as catharsis. For instance, a group member reported that all of her chronic neck pains were gone after she expressed some very painful feelings. Catharsis is frequently associated with the experiential approaches, especially Gestalt therapy and psychodrama.

Emotional release plays an important part in many kinds of groups, and the expression of feelings facilitates trust and cohesion. But it is not true that the only real work is done by catharsis. Members who do not have an emotional release may become convinced that they are not really "working." Leaders may become

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seduced by the intensity that comes with catharsis and press for such releases without having a clear direction or the confidence and skill to work with the material that is uncovered. Sometimes beginning leaders feel that only the cathartic expressions are meaningful, and they may underestimate the power of other work done by members. Group leaders do well to ask: "What am I doing, why am I doing it, and how capable am I and the members of handling such work?"

Although it is often healing, catharsis by itself is limited in terms of producing long-lasting changes. Members need to learn how to make sense of their catharsis, and one way of doing so is by putting words to those intense emotions and attempting to understand how they influence and control their everyday behavior. Often the best route to assisting members in examining their thought patterns and behaviors is by encouraging them to identify, express, and deal with what they are feeling. It can be tempting to emphasize catharsis and view the release of emotions as an end in itself, but this is not the final goal of the group experience.

After the release of feeling, it is essential to work with a member's insights associated with the emotional situation and the cognitions underlying these emotional patterns. Ideally, group leaders will help members link their emotional exploration to cognitive and behavioral work. Group leaders can help members face intense feelings and at the same time encourage them to translate insights into positive action within the group setting. Emotional work can be furthered by drawing on concepts and techniques from the cognitive behavioral orientations illustrated in Chapter 4.

EXAMPLE: Selene learned that she could experience both love and anger toward her mother. For years she had buried her resentment over what she saw as her mother's continual attempts to control her life. In one session Selene allowed herself to feel and to fully express her resentment to her mother in a symbolic way. Through a role play the group leader assisted Selene in telling her mother many of the things that had contributed to her feelings of resentment. She felt a great sense of relief after having expressed these pent-up emotions. The leader cautioned her about the dangers of repeating in real life everything that she had just said in the therapy session. It would not be necessary to harshly confront her mother and to expose the full range of her pain and anger. Instead, Selene learned that it was important to understand how her resentment toward her mother was continuing to affect her now, both in her present dealings with her mother and in her relationship to others. The issue of control was a problem to Selene in all her relationships. By releasing her feelings she became more aware that everyone does not control her. It was essential that Selene clarify what she really wanted with her mother and what was still keeping her from getting closer to her and to others. Selene can choose what she wants to tell her mother, and she can also deal with her in more direct and honest ways than she has in the past.

The Cognitive Component

Members who *experience* feelings often have difficulty integrating what they learn from these experiences. Some conceptualization of the meaning of the intense

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feelings associated with certain experiences is essential to further deeper exploration of one's struggles. The cognitive component includes explaining, clarifying, interpreting, formulating ideas, and providing the cognitive framework for creating a new perspective on problems.

The cognitive behavioral approaches stress the thinking and doing aspects of behavior, and this emphasis can be productively integrated into experientially oriented groups (see Chapter 4). Yalom (2005b) cites substantial research demonstrating that to profit from a group experience the members require a cognitive framework that will enable them to put their here-and-now experiencing into perspective. When asking members to cognitively process an emotional experience, timing is crucial. If members are asked to make sense of an intense emotional experience too quickly, they may feel that the leader is insensitive. However, at some point members can be asked to put into words what expressing their emotions meant to them and what insights they may have gained.

EXAMPLE: Felix, the adolescent who expressed pent-up hurt, initially felt better after an outburst of crying, but he soon discounted the experience. Felix needed to put into words the meaning of his emotional interchange. He may have learned any of the following: that he was storing up feelings of anger toward his father, that he had a mixture of resentment and love for his father, that he had made a decision that his father would never change, that there were many things he could say to his father, or that there were numerous ways that he could act differently with his father. It was therapeutically important for him to release his bottled-up emotions. It was also essential that he clarify his insights and discover ways to use them to improve his relationship with his father.

Commitment to Change

The commitment to change involves members' being willing to make use of the tools offered by group process to explore ways of modifying their behavior. Participants need to remind themselves why they are in the group, and they need to formulate action plans and strategies to employ in their day-to-day existence to implement change. The group affords them the opportunity to plan realistically and responsibly and offers members the opportunity to evaluate the effectiveness of their actions. It is crucial for members to commit themselves to following through on their plans, and the group itself can help members develop the motivation to follow through with their commitments. If members find that carrying out some of their plans is difficult or if they do not do what they had planned, it is essential that they talk about these difficulties in the group sessions.

EXAMPLE: Pearl discovered her tendency to wait until the session was almost over to bring up her concerns. She described many situations in her life when she did not get what she wanted. She insisted that she wanted to make some changes and behave differently. The leader issued the following challenge:

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"Pearl, would you be willing to be the first to speak at the next group session? I'd like you to also think of at least one situation this week in which your needs are not being met because you are holding yourself back. What could you do to bring about a more positive outcome for yourself?" Thus the leader provided Pearl with alternatives for taking the initiative to try new ways of acting, both in real life and in the group sessions. If she continued to sabotage meeting her needs by not doing what she said she would do, the leader and members might confront her by sharing their observations.

Freedom to Experiment

The group situation provides a safe place for experimentation with new behavior. Members are able to show facets of themselves that they often keep hidden in everyday situations. In the accepting environment of a group, a shy member can exhibit spontaneous behavior and be outgoing. A person who typically is very quiet may experiment with being more verbal. After trying new behaviors, members can gauge how much they want to change their existing behavior.

EXAMPLE: Yesenia said she was tired of being so shy all the time and would like to let people know her better. The leader responded, "Yesenia, would you be willing to pick out a person in this group who seems the opposite of you?" Yesenia identified Mayra. After getting Mayra's approval, the leader suggested to Yesenia: "Go around to each person in the room, and act in a way that you have seen Mayra behave. Assume her body posture, her gestures, and her tone of voice. Then, tell each person something that you would want them to know about you." What Yesenia gained from this experiment was the recognition that she did possess the capacity to be outgoing and that she could practice giving expression to this dimension of herself.

As a variation, Yesenia could have been asked to share with all of the members her observations and reactions to them. Yet another variation would have included asking Mayra to be Yesenia's coach and assist her in carrying out this task. It can be surprising how outgoing members are when they pretend to be in someone else's skin.

Humor

Humor can help group members get insight or a new perspective on their problems, and it can be a source of healing. But humor should never be used to embarrass a group member. Effective feedback can sometimes be given in a humorous way. Laughing at oneself and *with* others can be extremely therapeutic. As a matter of fact, much has been written about the healing effects of humor, and some workshops focus on the therapeutic aspects of humor.

Humor requires seeing one's problems in a new perspective. Laughter and humor can draw everyone in the group closer. Humor often puts problems in a new light, and it sets a tone in a group indicating that work can occur in a context

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of fun. The power of humor as a therapeutic tool is often underrated. Humor often balances the relationship between members and leaders, it can empower members, and it establishes an environment that is maximally therapeutic to members. Humor is a coping strategy that enables group members to find the absurd or ironic aspects in their situations. It also has a transformational character in that it enables members to gain a sense of perspective and control over situations not under their direct control. Like self-disclosure, humor can be overused or misused. Is the leader uncomfortable with a situation and using humor to lighten the mood of the group or to decrease the leader's own anxieties? Does people laughing satisfy the leader's need to be liked by group members? Group leaders should be aware of the purpose for which humor is used and monitor how members perceive it.

Spontaneity seems to be the key to using humor effectively, for "planned humor" can certainly fall flat. A level of trust must be established before taking too many liberties with humor. This brand of humor is not laughing *at* people but laughing *with* them out of a sense of affection and caring.

EXAMPLE: Samuel was a serious person who tended to sit back quietly and observe others in the group. When the leader challenged Samuel on his observational stance, he said that he could write a comedy about this group. The leader knew that he was a creative writer and, hoping to get him involved in verbal ways, asked him to write in his journal a comical account of what he saw taking place in the group. When he later read parts of what he had written in his journal about this group, just about everyone in the group laughed. In the process Samuel also shared many of his own reactions to others in the group through his humor. Clearly he was not laughing at them, yet he was able to capture some of the humorous dimensions of what was taking place. By getting active through humor he was able to give a number of members some very insightful feedback, which they would have been denied had he continued sitting silently and observing others. In his account he was able to capture some very funny sides of his own behavior, which gave others a completely different picture of him.

LO11

Coleader Issues During the Working Stage

When we colead groups or intensive workshops, we become energized if the group is motivated to work. In effective groups, the members do the bulk of the work, for they bring up subjects they want to talk about and demonstrate a willingness to be known. Between group sessions we devote time to discussing our reactions to group members, to thinking of ways of involving the various members in transactions with one another, and to exploring possible ways of helping participants understand their behavior in the group and resolve some of their conflicts. We also look critically at what we are doing as leaders, examine the impact of our behavior on the group, and analyze how the group is affecting us. Toward this end we

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reflect on the patterns of feedback we have received from the members about how our behavior has affected them. We also talk about the process and dynamics of the group. If we find that we have differing perceptions of the group process, we discuss our differences.

Topics for Coleader Meetings

We cannot overemphasize the importance of meeting with your coleader throughout the duration of the group. Many suggestions in earlier chapters for issues for discussion at these meetings also apply to the working stage. Here are a few other topics that are particularly relevant to the working stage.

Ongoing Evaluation of the Group Coleaders can make it a practice to devote some time to appraising the direction the group is taking and its level of productivity. In a closed group, one with a predetermined termination date (such as 16 weeks), coleaders would do well to evaluate the group's progress around the 8th week. This evaluation can be a topic of discussion both privately and in the group itself. If both leaders agree that the group seems to be bogging down and that members are losing interest, for example, leaders should bring these perceptions into the group so that the members can look at their degree of satisfaction with their direction and progress.

Discussion of Techniques It is useful to discuss techniques and leadership styles with a coleader. One of the leaders might be hesitant to try any technique because of a fear of making a mistake, because of not knowing where to go next, or because of passively waiting for permission from the coleader to introduce techniques. Such issues, along with any stylistic differences between leaders, are topics for exploration.

Theoretical Orientations As we mentioned earlier, it is not essential that coleaders share the same theory of group work, for sometimes differing theoretical preferences can blend nicely. You can learn a lot from discussing theory as it applies to practice. Therefore, we encourage you to read, attend workshops and special seminars, and discuss what you are learning with your coleader. Doing so can result in bringing to the group sessions some new and interesting variations.

Self-Disclosure Issues Coleaders should explore their sense of appropriate and therapeutic self-disclosure. For example, if you are willing to share with members your reactions that pertain to group issues yet are reserved in disclosing personal outside issues, whereas your coleader freely and fully talks about her marital situation, members may perceive you as holding back. This issue, too, can be discussed both in the group and privately with your coleader.

Confrontation Issues What we have just said about self-disclosure also applies to confrontation. You can imagine the problems that could ensue from your coleader's practice of harsh and unrelenting confrontations to get members to open up if

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you believe in providing support to the exclusion of any confrontation. You might easily be labeled as the "good leader" and your coleader as the "bad leader." If such differences in style exist, the two of you need to talk about this at length if the group is not to suffer.



Journal Prompts

The following questions are meant to serve as prompts for members of a group during the working stage. If you are leading groups, you might find these to be useful for your group members to discuss in group or to journal about between sessions. In addition, we encourage you to think about your responses to these questions as either a real or an imagined group member.

1. What have you observed that demonstrates that a high level of trust or cohesion between group members has developed?
2. What patterns of communication do you see happening in this stage of the group?
3. How satisfied are you with your level of participation? Explain.
4. In what ways are you willing to take risks or not in the group?
5. How are members and the leaders handling conflicts that occur in the group?
6. How are you dealing with feedback and confrontation from group members or from the leaders?
7. In what ways do you feel supported or not by the group members or the leaders?
8. What changes do you feel hopeful about making as a result of being in this group?
9. How willing are you to take action to bring about change outside of the group?

Points to Remember

Working Stage of a Group

Working Stage Characteristics

When a group reaches the working stage, its central characteristics include the following:

- The level of trust and cohesion is high.
- Communication within the group is open and involves an accurate expression of what is being experienced.
- Members interact with one another freely and directly.
- There is a willingness to take risks and to make oneself known to others; members bring to the group personal topics they want to explore and understand better.
- Conflict among members, if it exists, is recognized and dealt with directly and effectively.
- Feedback is given freely and accepted and considered nondefensively.
- Confrontation is caring and respectful and is accepted as a challenge to examine one's behavior.
- Members are willing to work outside the group to achieve behavioral changes.

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- Participants feel supported in their attempts to change and are willing to risk new behavior.
- Members feel hopeful that they can change if they are willing to take action; they do not feel helpless.

Member Tasks and Functions

The working stage is characterized by the exploration of personally meaningful material. To reach this stage, members will have to fulfill these tasks and roles:

- Bring into group sessions personal concerns they are willing to discuss.
- Offer feedback and remain open to feedback from others even though this may increase anxiety for some members.
- Be willing to practice new skills and behaviors in daily life and bring the results to the sessions; insight alone will not produce change.
- Be willing to take risks; the work of the group will stop if members become too relaxed and comfortable.
- Continually assess their level of satisfaction with the group and actively take steps to change their level of involvement in the sessions if necessary.

Leader Functions

Leaders address these central leadership functions at the working stage:

- Continue to model appropriate behavior, especially caring confrontation, and disclose ongoing reactions to the group.
- Support the members' willingness to take risks and assist them in carrying this into their daily living.
- Interpret the meaning of behavior patterns at appropriate times so that members will be able to engage in a deeper level of self-exploration and consider alternative behaviors.
- Explore common themes that provide for some universality, and link one or more members' work with that of others in the group.
- Emphasize the importance of translating insight into action; encourage members to practice new skills.
- Promote those behaviors that will increase the level of cohesion.



Exercises

Assessment of the Working Stage

1. **Key Indicators.** What signs do you look for to determine whether a group has attained the working stage? Identify specific characteristics you see as especially related to this stage. To what degree has your group class evolved to the working stage? To what degree are you accomplishing your personal goals in the group?
2. **Changing Membership in Open Groups.** Assume that you are leading a group with a changing membership. Although there is a core of members who attend consistently, clients eventually terminate, and new members join the group. What obstacles will the members have to deal with if this group is to reach a working stage? How would you work to increase cohesion in this type of group? How would you handle the reality of members' terminating and new members' assimilating into the group?
3. **Personal and Appropriate Self-Disclosure.** What guidelines would you offer to members on appropriate self-disclosure? Can you explain to members the value of being personal and sharing who they are? How might you respond to this statement made by a member? "I don't see why there is so much emphasis on telling others what I think and feel. I've always been a private person, and all this personal talk makes me feel uncomfortable." How might you deal with this member in a voluntary group? In an involuntary group?

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4. **Effective Confrontation.** There are important differences between effective and ineffective confrontation. How would you explain this difference to group members? Think about how you might respond to a person who had been in your group for some time and who said, "I don't see why we focus so much on problems and on confronting people with negative feelings. All this makes me want to retreat. I'm afraid to say much because I'd rather hear positive feedback."

Questions for Discussion

In small groups, explore the following questions:

1. What are the major differences between a working and a nonworking group? Between a working and a nonworking member?
2. What three therapeutic factors do you consider to be most important in bringing about change during the working stage?
3. What specific guidelines would you follow to determine whether self-disclosure would be appropriate and facilitative for you as a leader?
4. What would you want to teach members during the working stage about giving and receiving feedback?
5. Although productive work can occur at all the stages of a group, not all groups reach what are described in this chapter as being characteristic of a working stage. What prevents a group from reaching a working stage?

Member's Weekly Evaluation of a Group

Directions: This evaluation exercise can be given to members at the end of each group session you may be leading to give you a quick index of the level of satisfaction of the members. You can summarize the results and begin a session with the trends you are noticing from the evaluation sheets. Have the members circle the appropriate number for each item, using the following scale:

1 or 2 = very weak
3 or 4 = moderately weak
5 or 6 = adequate
7 or 8 = moderately strong
9 or 10 = very strong

1. What degree of preparation (reacting, thinking about the topic, reading, and writing) did you do for this week?

   1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

2. How would you rate your involvement in the group today?

   1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

3. How would you rate the group's level of involvement?

   1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

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4. Rate yourself on the degree to which you saw yourself today as willing to take risks, to share with other members what you thought and felt, and to be an active participant.

   1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

5. To what degree do you feel satisfied with your experience in the group?

   1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

6. To what degree do you feel that the group dealt with issues in a personal and meaningful way (sharing feelings as opposed to intellectual discussion)?

   1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

7. To what degree do you experience trust within the group?

   1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

8. How would you rate the group leader's level of involvement and investment in today's session?

   1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

9. Rate your leader on the dimensions of his or her ability today to create a good working climate as characterized by warmth, respect, support, empathy, and trust.

   1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Guide to Groups in Action: Evolution and Challenges DVD and Workbook

Here are some suggestions for making use of this chapter along with the working stage segment of *Evolution of a Group*, the first program in *Groups in Action*.

1. **Characteristics of the Working Stage.** In a concise way, identify the key characteristics of a group in a working stage. On the DVD, how does the group seem different during the working stage than it did during the initial and transition stages? Review the section in this chapter on the contrasts between a working group and a nonworking group. How do these points apply to this group?
2. **Therapeutic Factors That Operate in Groups.** As you view the DVD, look for specific illustrations of members' work unfolding in that group. See the workbook for a few of the scenarios that are played out during the working stage by various members, and list examples of the work of different members and the therapeutic factors that are operating. What can you learn about the value of role playing, encouraging the group members to work in the here and now, and sharing reactions to one another? What is the value of members expressing their feelings over painful issues? What is the value of linking members together with common themes and pursuing work with several members at the same time? How does role playing influence the process of the group?

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On the DVD can you identify one member's work that acted as a catalyst to bring others into the interactions? Both the text and the DVD illustrate examples of symbolically speaking to a parent in one's primary language through role playing. What are you learning about techniques to facilitate self-exploration through symbolically dealing with a parent in a group? How does staying in the here and now enhance the depth of self-exploration?

3. **Working With Metaphors.** The DVD demonstrates ways we, as coleaders, can follow a client's lead by paying attention to his or her metaphors. What metaphors did you hear, and how would you work with them?
4. **Applying the DVD Group to Yourself.** As you view the working segment, answer these questions: Which member (or members) most stands out for you in this segment, and why? What leader functions do you see being illustrated?
5. **Using the Workbook.** Refer to Segment 4: Working Stage in the workbook and complete the inventories and exercises.

MindTap for Counseling

Additional resources can be found on CengageBrain.com and by logging into the MindTap course created by your professor. There you will find a variety of study tools and useful resources that include quizzes, videos, interactive exercises, and more.

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